SMALL BUSINESS BASICS · CANADA

Handling Online Reviews

Ask for them, reply to them, and deal with the hard ones

A plain-language guide for Canadian small-business owners

First edition · November 2026

Handling Online Reviews — Ask for them, reply to them, and deal with the hard ones

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Important. This guide is general information for Canadian small-business owners. It is not legal, tax, accounting, or financial advice, and it does not create a professional relationship of any kind. Rules, rates, forms, and software features change. Before you act, check the official source named in the guide and, where the stakes are real, talk to a qualified professional who knows your situation.

Nothing in this guide is legal advice. Review platforms set and change their own rules, and questions about fake reviews, privacy or defamation belong with the Competition Bureau, the platform, or a lawyer.

No result is promised. How useful any idea in this guide turns out to be depends on your business, your customers, your market, and how you apply it.

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Before you start

Online reviews are one of the few parts of your reputation you can see, read and answer. This guide covers where reviews live, the rules you need to stay inside, a simple routine for asking every customer, how to reply to positive, mixed and negative reviews, what to do about fake or harmful ones, and how to turn feedback into small improvements. The last part holds copy-ready templates, a feedback log, escalation steps and a one-page checklist.

It is written for Canadian small-business owners: sole proprietors and small teams such as cleaners, trades, salons, consultants, photographers, landscapers, tutors, food trucks and small shops. You do not need any marketing background. If you can send a text message and log in to a website, you can do everything in here.

This guide is general information, not legal advice. Rules on misleading advertising, privacy and defamation apply to reviews, and how they apply to your situation is a question for a lawyer. Where a rule matters, the guide names the official source to check, and you will find short reminders wherever you are close to a legal decision.

Platforms change. Review sites write their own policies and update their features and menus often. What this guide describes is accurate in general terms at the time of writing. Check each platform's current help pages before you rely on a specific feature or rule.

Using the templates. The templates are starting points. Change the wording until it sounds like you; a reply that reads like a form letter can feel worse to a customer than no reply at all. Placeholders look like this: [Customer first name]. Worksheets have fill-in lines. Print them, or copy them into a notebook or a simple spreadsheet.

Every main chapter ends with a short box of key points, so you can come back later and find the essentials quickly.

Why reviews deserve your time

Picture someone who has never heard of you. They need a furnace cleaned or a dog groomed. They find your name, and before they call, they read what other people wrote. Reviews let that stranger see what dealing with you is like (on time? clear about the price? tidy?), the kind of work you actually do, and, through your replies, how you behave when something goes wrong.

You cannot control what people write. You can control whether you ask, how you reply and what you change. Google says its local results are based mainly on relevance, distance and prominence, and no one can promise that reviews will change where you appear. This guide treats reviews as a way to show prospective customers the truth about your business, not as a ranking trick.

Where reviews live. Some examples, at the time of writing, in no particular order: Google Business Profile; reviews or recommendations on a Facebook Page; Yelp; Tripadvisor for food and travel; HomeStars and Houzz for home services; wedding directories and booking apps with star ratings; and testimonials on your own website. None of these is “best”, and some trades have their own directories that matter more.

Which to claim. Choose **one main platform** (a good start is whatever appears when you search your business name on a phone) and **one or two secondary ones**. Check everything else monthly. You can only reply on a listing you control, so claim each one first. On Google, a Business Profile must be verified before it is fully public and editable, and Google decides which verification methods it offers you. Check that your name, hours and contact details are correct, turn on review notifications, and write down who has login access.

KEY POINTS

- Reviews show a stranger what working with you is like and how you handle problems.
- Choose one main platform and one or two secondary ones.
- Claim and verify your listings so you can reply, and turn on notifications.

The rules: what you can and cannot do

Read this chapter twice. The rules come from Canadian law and from each platform's own policies. Where they differ, follow the stricter one. This is general information, not legal advice; if you are unsure whether something is allowed, ask a lawyer first.

Fake reviews and the Competition Act

The Competition Act prohibits false or misleading representations to the public. The Competition Bureau, which enforces it, has warned that these can be misleading:

- **fake reviews**, whether you write them, buy them or have someone else write them
- **reviews by owners or employees posing as customers**
- **hiding negative reviews** so your overall picture looks better than it is

The Bureau has also said that if you offer an incentive for a review on your own channels, the incentive should be disclosed. Confirm the current guidance at Competition Bureau Canada (competition-bureau.canada.ca).

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Do not buy reviews, swap reviews with other businesses, review yourself under another name, or post fake negative reviews of a competitor. All of these can be misleading.

Staff, family and friends

Neither you nor your staff should review your business. Family and friends are a grey area: if your sister genuinely hired you and paid, she is a customer, but some platforms treat reviews from people close to the business as a conflict of interest. Read the platform's policy first, and when in doubt, don't ask.

Incentives and review gating

An incentive is anything of value given in return for a review: a discount, a free add-on, a gift card, a draw entry.

- **On Google:** Google does not allow incentivized reviews at all, even if you would accept a negative one.
- **On your own channels** (website, printed testimonials): if you offer an incentive, the Competition Bureau says it should be disclosed. Many owners find it simpler not to offer one.
- **On other platforms:** check each platform's rules. Some have their own limits on asking for reviews at all.

Review gating means screening customers first and only sending the happy ones to a public review site. For example, a form that sends five-star answers to Google and everyone else to a private form. Google does not allow review gating, and it runs straight into the Bureau's concern about hiding negative reviews.

The rule for this whole guide: **ask everyone, in the same way, at the same point in your process.** You can still invite private feedback, as long as every customer gets the same chance to post publicly.

Your website and your replies

Testimonials

Post only testimonials from real customers, and keep a record of where each came from. Get permission, use only the name the customer agrees to, and do not edit a testimonial so it changes its meaning. If you show a star rating or review feed, do not quietly remove the negative ones. If you want to feature a hand-picked selection, ask a lawyer how to present it so it does not give a misleading overall impression.

Privacy

Anyone can read your reply. Do not reveal a customer's personal information in it: their full name if they did not use it, address, phone, job or appointment details, purchases, health, payment history, or anything said in confidence.

Private-sector privacy law applies to personal information collected in commercial activity: PIPEDA (the Personal Information Protection and Electronic Documents Act) federally, with separate laws in Alberta, British Columbia and Quebec. The safe habit is to reply in general terms and move details to a private conversation.

Platform rules

Each platform decides what it will remove and how you may ask for reviews. On Google, breaking the guidelines can lead to suspension, and owners cannot delete reviews; they can reply publicly and report reviews that break Google's policies. Check each platform's rules.

KEY POINTS

- Fake reviews, staff posing as customers and hiding negative reviews can be misleading under the Competition Act.
- Google does not allow incentives or review gating; disclose any incentive on your own channels.
- Ask everyone, the same way.
- Never reveal a customer's personal information in a public reply.
- Where the law and a platform's rules differ, follow the stricter one.

Asking for reviews

Asking can feel awkward. The fix is to make it routine: the same ask, at the same moment, for every customer, so it stops being a decision you make each time.

When and who

Ask at the point where the customer has just received what they paid for: at the end of a cleaning visit, at handover on a renovation, at checkout in a salon, when you deliver a consultant's report, or on the receipt at a food truck. Pick one moment and write it down. For repeat customers, such as a weekly cleaning client, choose a fixed point too, for example after the first month, rather than asking after every visit. If a job still has an open problem, finish the job first, then ask exactly as you would anyone else. The point is not to wait for a good mood; it is to ask once the work is done.

Whoever has the last real conversation with the customer is usually the best person to ask. They need the exact words (see the templates), the rule that everyone gets asked, the rule that nothing is ever offered in return, and a place to note that the ask happened.

How to ask, and making it easy

Use more than one channel, with the same message:

- **In person:** a short, plain request. No pressure, no speech.
- **Text message:** short, with the direct link, sent the same day.
- **Email:** a little longer, with the link, sent the same day or the next.
- **Receipt or invoice line:** one sentence and a link or QR code.

> NOTE
>
> If you send review requests by email or text, keep Canada's Anti-Spam Legislation (CASL) in mind. It applies to commercial electronic messages, and promotional messages need consent. Keep review requests plain, do not bundle offers into them, and ask a lawyer if you are unsure how CASL applies.

Every extra click is a chance to give up, so keep the path short:

1. **Get a direct link.** At the time of writing, Google Business Profile offers a shareable link that opens your review form; look for the option about asking for reviews, or check Google Business Profile Help. Other platforms have similar links.
2. **Test it** on a phone and a computer. It should open the review form, not just your listing.
3. **Make a QR code** for the same link with any QR code generator, and test it with two different phones before printing.

4. **Put the link and code where customers already look:** invoice or receipt template, email signature, a card left after the job, a sign at the counter.
5. **Save the link where your team can find it,** such as a pinned note on the shared phone.

If a customer raises a problem when you ask

Deal with the problem first. Thank them for telling you, fix what you can, and still offer the review link, the same as you would to anyone else. Do not talk them out of posting or suggest they keep it private instead.

Follow up once, then stop

One gentle follow-up a few days later is reasonable. After that, stop; more reminders start to feel like pressure. Note who you asked and when, so no one gets asked twice or forgotten. A column in your job list is enough, and keeping a copy of your scripts and messages alongside it gives you a simple record that you ask every customer the same way, with nothing offered in return. If a customer says they would rather not leave a review, thank them, note it, and do not ask again. Their business matters more than their review.

EXAMPLE

Say you run a two-person house-cleaning business in Truro. At the end of every first clean, the cleaner says the in-person script and leaves a card with a QR code. That evening you text the direct link. Four days later, if no review has appeared, you send one follow-up email, then mark “asked” and “followed up” in your booking notes and stop. Every customer gets the same three touches, whether the clean went perfectly or not.

KEY POINTS

- Pick one moment to ask, and ask every customer at that moment.
- Give whoever asks a script and clear rules: everyone, no incentives.
- Use a direct link and a QR code, tested on real phones.
- Follow up once, then stop. Keep requests plain and mind CASL.

Replying to reviews

Positive reviews: short, specific, varied

A positive review is a customer doing you a favour. A reply says thank you and shows readers that a real person runs the business. Good replies are:

- **Short.** Two to four sentences. The review is the star.
- **Specific.** Mention something from the review, so it is clear you read it.
- **Varied.** If every reply says “Thanks for the kind words, we appreciate your business,” the replies start to look automatic. Rotate a few openings and closings and always add one specific line.

Leave out personal details the customer did not mention, sales pitches (“Don’t forget our spring special”) and strings of keywords. Write for a person, not a search engine.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Review (five stars):** “Ana re-did my colour after another salon botched it. She took her time and explained what she was doing.”
>
> **Reply:** “Thank you for trusting us with a colour fix. Corrections take patience, and we’re glad the extra time showed. Ana will be happy to hear this.”

Staff names, star-only reviews and other languages

When a customer names the person who served them, pass on the thanks. Use only the first name the customer used, or one the staff member has agreed to have used publicly, add no other details, and share the review with them privately too.

Some reviewers leave a rating with no text. A short, warm line is enough for a good one. For a low star-only rating, use the “unclear” template: thank them, say you would like to understand, and invite them to contact you.

When you can, reply in the language of the review. If you cannot write it well, a short, careful reply in English is better than a machine translation that says something you did not mean.

Mixed reviews

A mixed review praises one thing and criticizes another: “Great work on the bathroom, but they left a mess in the driveway.” The reviewer has told you exactly what to fix. A useful order:

1. Thank them.
2. Acknowledge the positive briefly.
3. Address the concern directly. Do not skip it.

4. Say what you are changing, in general terms.
5. Offer a direct contact if anything is left to sort out.

> EXAMPLE
>
> **Review (three stars):** “Bathroom tile looks great. But the crew left mortar bags in the driveway for two days.”
>
> **Reply:** “Thank you for the honest review. We’re glad the tile turned out well, and you’re right that leaving material in your driveway wasn’t acceptable. We’ve added a final site clean-up to our end-of-day checklist. If anything is still left over, please call us at [phone] and we’ll come by.”

Negative reviews: pause, then investigate

A negative review stings, especially after hard work. The steps below give you a calm, repeatable process, so you are not writing a reply at 11 p.m. in a bad mood.

Do not reply straight away. A reply written in anger lasts as long as the review does. Remember who the reply is really for: future customers deciding whether you are fair and reasonable. Then aim to reply within a day or two once you have the facts.

Before you write a word:

1. **Is this a real customer?** Search your records for the name, date and job. If you cannot find them, see the next chapter on fake and misdirected reviews.
2. **What do your records say?** Check the quote, invoice, messages, photos and notes.
3. **Talk to whoever did the work,** privately and calmly.
4. **Is the complaint fair, partly fair or wrong?** Be honest, and look for at least one point worth fixing.
5. **Decide what you are willing to offer** (a redo, a call, an apology, a credit, a process change) before you contact the customer.

The reply framework

Keep the public reply short and calm, and follow five steps:

1. **Thank.** Thank them for the feedback. It sets the tone.
2. **Acknowledge.** Show you understand the concern, in general terms. “I’m sorry this wasn’t what you expected” apologizes for the experience without agreeing to things that did not happen.
3. **Take it offline.** Invite them to contact you directly, by name, with a phone number or email.
4. **Fix.** Contact them privately if you can identify them, listen, and offer what you decided on.
5. **Follow up.** Check that the fix worked. If it is true and makes sense, add a short public update under your reply.

Steps 1 to 3 go in the public reply. Steps 4 and 5 happen privately. Reviewers can usually edit or remove their own reviews. A reviewer may update theirs after a good private conversation, or may not, and that is fine; your calm reply is already doing its job for future readers. Do not chase them about it.

What not to do

- **Do not argue.** A point-by-point rebuttal reads as defensive. If you must correct an important fact, do it once, briefly.
- **Do not reveal details.** “Our records show you cancelled twice” is both a privacy problem and a tone problem.
- **Do not offer anything in exchange for an edit.** Offering a refund or anything else to change or remove a review is an incentive. Fix the problem because it is right, privately, and never make a remedy conditional on the review changing.
- **Do not ask them to delete the review.** If they update it on their own, that is their choice.
- **Do not post photos to prove a point.** Pictures of a customer’s home or project can identify them.
- **Do not paste the same reply** onto every negative review.
- **Do not blame a staff member publicly.**
- **Do not threaten.** No lawyers, lawsuits or “consequences” in a reply.

> NOTE
>
> If you work in a regulated profession, such as health care, your regulator may have rules about replying to reviews, including whether you may even confirm that someone was a client. Check with your regulator before you reply.

Price complaints

Do not quote their invoice or the amount. Explain in general terms what goes into your pricing if it helps. If the surprise came from poor communication on your side, say so and say how you are fixing it, such as written quotes for every job. Offer to go over the bill privately.

EXAMPLE

Say you run a small landscaping company in Moncton. A one-star review says: “Booked a spring clean-up. They showed up a day late with no call, and the price was way more than I was told.”

Your notes show the crew was rained out and nobody called. The crew also hauled away a pile of brush at the customer’s request, which added to the bill, but no one explained the extra charge.

Your public reply: “Thank you for the feedback. You’re right that we should have called when the weather pushed your visit back, and we’re sorry we didn’t. We also should have explained any change to the price before doing extra work. I’d like to go over this with you directly. Please call me at [phone]. — [Your first name], owner”

Privately, you call, apologize, explain the charge and offer a credit for the brush removal, since it was never agreed in advance. You do not mention the review. You add two lines to your process: “Call if running late” and “Get a yes before extra work.”

Reviews that mention your staff

Be fair to the customer and to your team member:

- **Talk privately first.** Your team member may have context the review leaves out.
- **Do not name or blame them in your reply.** “We’ve followed up with our team” is enough.
- **Support them.** Tell them you will handle the reply, and that they should not reply or contact the customer themselves.
- **Handle real problems privately.** If it becomes an employment issue, follow your province’s employment standards and get advice.
- **Report personal attacks** on a staff member to the platform.

Afterwards, check in with your team member again. A fair process, handled privately, shows the rest of your team that you will back them up and also take customers seriously.

KEY POINTS

- Reply to positive reviews with a short, specific, varied thank-you, with no personal details or sales pitches.
- Treat mixed reviews as free advice: address the concern and say what you are changing.
- For negative reviews, pause and investigate, then reply within a day or two of having the facts.
- Use the framework: thank, acknowledge, take it offline, fix, follow up.
- Never argue, reveal details, threaten, blame staff in public, or offer anything in exchange for changing a review.

Fake, wrong and harmful reviews

Now and then a review may be fake, meant for another business, abusive, or worse. This chapter covers what you can do, and what you should not. It is general information, not legal advice; if a review may be defamatory or threatening, talk to a lawyer.

What you see	What it might be	First step
Someone you cannot find in your records	Wrong business, a customer's relative, or fake	Reply politely; report if it clearly breaks policy
A service you do not offer	Wrong business	Reply politely; report as off-topic
A burst of similar reviews	Spam or a coordinated attack	Document; report each one
A review you suspect a competitor or ex-employee wrote	Conflict of interest or fake	Document and report; never accuse publicly
Insults, threats, personal information	Policy violation, possibly illegal	Report, document, consider a lawyer or police
A false statement that could harm your reputation	Possibly defamatory	Report, document, talk to a lawyer

Reporting through the platform

Every major platform has a way to report a review. On Google, owners cannot delete reviews but can report those that break Google's policies. When you report:

1. **Read the platform's policy** and find the specific rule broken: spam, off-topic, conflict of interest, harassment, personal information.
2. **Use the platform's own reporting tool** and pick the matching reason.
3. **Keep it factual.** "Not in our customer records and describes a service we do not offer" beats "obviously fake and malicious."
4. **Note what you reported, when and why,** and any way to check status or appeal.
5. **Accept that the answer may be no.** An unfair review is not necessarily against the rules, and negative opinions from real customers are generally allowed.

While you wait, you can usually reply. Keep it short and neutral: say you cannot find a record of them, invite them to contact you, and do not accuse them of lying or being a competitor, even if you are sure.

WATCH OUT

Do not respond to a fake or unfair review by asking customers, friends or staff to post positive reviews to “balance it out.” Organized reviews like that can break platform rules and can be misleading.

Threats, defamation and private information

Some reviews threaten you, your family or your staff; make false statements of fact that could damage your reputation (for example, accusing you of a crime); or reveal private information such as a home address. Defamation is a legal question, and only a lawyer can tell you whether a review crosses that line. In these cases:

1. **Never threaten the reviewer.** No “my lawyer will be in touch.”
2. **Document everything.** Take screenshots showing the review, the reviewer’s name or profile, the date and the web address, and note when you took them. Keep them in one folder with your report notes.
3. **Report the review** under the most specific rule that applies.
4. **If anyone’s safety is at risk,** contact your local police.
5. **Consider talking to a lawyer,** especially if the review stays up and you believe it is defamatory.
6. **Decide whether to reply at all.** A short line such as “We take this seriously and have reported it” is sometimes better than silence, and sometimes saying nothing is wiser. A lawyer can help you decide.

KEY POINTS

- Check your records before deciding a review is fake or misdirected.
- Report through the platform, citing the rule broken, and keep notes.
- Reply neutrally while you wait. Never accuse a reviewer publicly.
- For threats, defamation or private information: document, report, consider a lawyer, call police if anyone is at risk.

Turning reviews into a routine

Reviews are free feedback. It can help to treat them less as a scoreboard and more as a notebook of what to keep doing and what to fix.

A simple feedback log

Keep one log for all feedback: reviews, comments at the counter, emails, phone complaints. A notebook or a four-column spreadsheet works (a blank version is in the templates chapter). Keep entries short, and leave out personal information you do not need; “kitchen job, Nov 2” is usually enough to find the file. Store the log securely, like any business record.

Once a month, read it top to bottom. What comes up more than once? What do people praise, so you can protect it when you get busy? Did last month’s change make a difference? Then pick **one** change for this month and tell the team. Small changes are easier to stick with, and easier to check, than a long list of resolutions.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a mobile dog-grooming van in Antigonish. Your log shows three comments in two months about not knowing when the van would arrive. You add a “15 minutes away” text to your routine. Next month the arrival-time comments are gone from your log, and a new review mentions the handy text. Listen, change one thing, check.

A weekly routine and who does what

Set aside about 20 minutes on the same day each week and work through this list:

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Main and secondary platforms checked for new reviews
- [ ] New positive reviews answered (short, specific, varied)
- [ ] Every negative or mixed review answered or in progress
- [ ] Private follow-ups done for last week’s complaints
- [ ] Status of any reports checked
- [ ] New feedback added to the log
- [ ] Review requests sent for every job finished this week
- [ ] One good review shared with the team
- [ ] Monthly: pattern review done, links and QR codes tested

Even in a two-person business, decide who asks, who sends follow-ups, who replies to positive reviews, and who handles negative reviews and reports (usually the owner). Write it on the team roles worksheet. Ground rules: only approved people reply, as the business and never from personal accounts; staff never reply to reviews about themselves or contact reviewers on their own; no one reviews the business or asks friends to; and anyone can flag a review to the owner.

Catching up and keeping things tidy

If you have a backlog of unanswered reviews, do not try to clear it in one sitting. Start with the most recent ones and any negative or mixed reviews, then work back a few at a time as part of your weekly routine. A thoughtful reply to an older review is still worth posting.

A few times a year, tidy up the system itself. Remove login access for anyone who has left. Check that every platform listing still shows the right hours, phone number and service area. Reread your ask messages and reply templates, and refresh any that have started to sound stale. Keep your screenshots, report notes and feedback log together in one folder, so you can find them quickly if you ever need them.

Share good reviews with the team, including the staff member's name where the customer used it. When a negative review points to a real problem, share the lesson, not the blame: "We had a complaint about clean-up, so it's on the checklist now."

KEY POINTS

- Keep one simple feedback log, without unnecessary personal details.
- Once a month, look for patterns and pick one change.
- Spend about 20 minutes a week on a fixed routine.
- Decide who asks, who replies and who reports, and write it down.

Templates and worksheets

Change these until they sound like you, and read each reply out loud before you post it.

Asking for a review

TEMPLATE

In-person script

“Thanks again for having us today. If you have a minute this week, we’d really appreciate a review on [platform]. It helps people in the area see what working with us is like. I’ll text you the link so it’s easy. Whatever you think, we’d like to hear it.”

Receipt or invoice line

Thank you for your business. We’d welcome your honest review: [short link] or scan the code.

TEMPLATE

Text message (same day)

Hi [Customer first name], it’s [Your name] from [Business name]. Thanks for choosing us today. If you have a moment, we’d be grateful for an honest review: [direct link]. Thank you.

One follow-up (a few days later, text or email)

Hi [Customer first name], a quick follow-up from [Business name]. If you have a moment, an honest review would mean a lot: [direct link]. No need to reply. Thanks again.

TEMPLATE

Email (same day or next day)

Subject: Thanks from [Business name]

Hi [Customer first name],

Thank you for choosing [Business name] for your [type of job]. If you have a couple of minutes, we’d be grateful for an honest review here: [direct link]

It helps people in [town or area] know what to expect from us. And if anything wasn’t right, please reply or call me at [phone]. I’d like to know.

Thanks again,
[Your name], [Business name]

Replying to reviews

TEMPLATE

1. Positive review

Thank you, [first name as shown on the review]. We're glad the [type of job] turned out the way you hoped, and [specific detail from the review] is exactly what we aim for. [Staff first name, if mentioned] will be happy to hear it.

2. Short positive or star-only review

Thank you for the [five-star rating / kind words]. We appreciate you taking the time, and we're glad you chose us.

TEMPLATE

3. Negative review about service

Thank you for letting us know. I'm sorry your experience fell short, and I understand why [general concern, e.g. "a late arrival with no call"] was frustrating. I'd like to hear more and make this right. Please contact me at [phone] or [email]. — [Your first name], [role]

4. Negative review about price

Thank you for the feedback. We work hard to be clear about pricing up front, and I'm sorry if that didn't happen here. Our prices reflect [general factors, e.g. "insured, trained staff and quality materials"], but you should never be surprised by a bill. I'd be glad to go over yours with you at [phone] or [email]. — [Your first name]

TEMPLATE

5. Unclear review or possibly not a customer

Thank you for taking the time to post this. We take every review seriously, but we can't find a record that matches your description. Please contact us at [phone] or [email] so we can look into it.

6. Mixed review

Thank you for the honest review. We're glad [the positive point] worked out well, and you're right that [the concern] wasn't up to our standard. We've [general change, e.g. "added a final clean-up step to every job"] so it doesn't happen again. If anything is left to sort out, please call us at [phone].

TEMPLATE

7. Negative review that mentions a staff member

Thank you for your feedback. I'm sorry your visit didn't go as it should have. I've followed up with our team, and I'd like to hear more from you directly at [phone] or [email]. — [Your first name], owner

8. Private message after a negative review

Hi [Customer first name], this is [Your name] from [Business name]. I'm sorry about [general concern]. Could we set up a quick call so I can understand what happened and see how to make it right? You can reach me at [phone], or reply with a good time.

9. Reply to a review you have reported

Thank you for your comments. We can't find a record of this visit and have asked [platform] to look into it. If we've missed something, please call us at [phone].

10. Public update after a fix (only if true)

Update: Thank you for speaking with us. We're glad we could sort this out, and we appreciate the chance to put it right.

Never make an offer conditional on the review being changed or removed, and never mention the review as part of the remedy.

Escalation steps for a problem review

Work through these in order and stop at the first that applies.

1. **Pause.** Do not reply yet.
2. **Is anyone's safety at risk** (a threat, a home address posted)? Screenshot it, contact local police, report it and consider a lawyer. Do not reply until you have advice.
3. **Does it reveal private information** about anyone? Screenshot it, report it under the platform's personal information rule, and never repeat the information.

4. **Is it a false statement of fact that could seriously harm your reputation?** Screenshot it, report it, and talk to a lawyer about whether it may be defamatory. Never threaten the reviewer.
5. **Can you find this person in your records?** If not, reply with template 5 or 9, and report it if it clearly breaks platform policy (spam, wrong business, conflict of interest).
6. **Is it a real customer with a complaint?** Investigate, reply with template 3, 4, 6 or 7, then fix and follow up privately.
7. **Record it** in the feedback log with what you did and the date.

WORKSHEET

Review date and platform: _____

Screenshots saved (where): _____

Reported on (date) and reason chosen: _____

Outcome, and any lawyer or police contact: _____

Feedback log and team roles

Date	Source	What they said	Action
Nov 2	Google	Late, no call	Added “call if late” step

WORKSHEET

Pattern I noticed this month: _____

One change I will make: _____

Asks for reviews: _____

Sends follow-ups: _____

Replies to positive reviews: _____

Replies to negative reviews and reports problems: _____

Review links and QR codes saved at: _____

Checklist

Use this list to set up your review system, then keep the weekly routine from the “Turning reviews into a routine” chapter going.

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Main platform and one or two secondary platforms chosen
- [ ] Listings claimed and verified, with correct name, hours and contact details
- [ ] Review notifications go to an inbox someone reads
- [ ] List of who has login access, kept up to date
- [ ] Team knows: no fake reviews, no staff reviews, no incentives on Google, ask everyone
- [ ] Any incentive on your own channels clearly disclosed
- [ ] Website testimonials are real, permitted and unedited, with records kept
- [ ] Direct review link tested on phone and computer
- [ ] QR code tested and added to invoices, receipts or cards
- [ ] One moment in your process chosen for asking
- [ ] Ask scripts and messages adapted to your voice, with no promotions bundled in
- [ ] Record kept of who was asked and when
- [ ] Reply templates saved where approved repliers can reach them
- [ ] Negative review process agreed: pause, investigate, thank, acknowledge, take offline, fix, follow up
- [ ] Rules agreed: no personal details in replies; no remedy conditional on changing a review
- [ ] Escalation steps printed
- [ ] Feedback log started and team roles written down
- [ ] Weekly 20-minute routine on the calendar

Where to learn more

Rules and platform policies change, so check these sources before you rely on anything in this guide.

Official sources

- **Competition Bureau Canada** (competition-bureau.canada.ca): guidance on false or misleading representations, including fake reviews, reviews by owners or employees, and disclosing incentives. You can also contact the Bureau there.
- **Google Business Profile Help** (support.google.com/business): Google's current review policies, including fake content, incentives and review gating, and how to reply to and report reviews.
- **Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada** (priv.gc.ca): plain-language information on PIPEDA and your duties for customers' personal information.
- **Provincial privacy commissioners:** in Alberta, British Columbia or Quebec, check your province's commissioner for the private-sector privacy law that applies.
- **Canada's anti-spam legislation:** search "Canada's anti-spam legislation" on canada.ca for official information on CASL.
- **Each review platform's business help pages:** read the review and content policies for every platform you use.

Talk to a professional

- **A lawyer,** if a review may be defamatory, or you are unsure about an incentive, a testimonial practice, privacy or CASL. Your provincial law society can help you find one.
- **Your professional regulator,** if you work in a regulated profession and want to know what you may say in a reply.
- **Your local police,** if a review threatens anyone's safety.

This guide is general information, not legal advice. When a decision has legal consequences, get advice that fits your situation.